

Book I - The Sagent Creed

Part 2 - The Shaken Jar

Chapter 07 - The Thornbush King

EP02 — The Thornbush King

Series: Sagent Creed **Type:** Mythic Monologue **Core Concept:** Every part has a role. The thorn that tries to wear the crown becomes catastrophic.

Source Material

From *The Spiral Steward*:

"In that ancient story [Judges 9], the trees seek a ruler, and one by one the olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine decline the crown, because each has a purpose, a function, a role that it cannot abandon without ceasing to be what it is. It is the thornbush — the bramble, the plant with no fruit, no oil, no sweetness to offer — that finally accepts the kingship. And the thornbush makes a terrible king, because thorns were never meant to rule."

"In any living system, no part is above another. No part rules the whole. Every part is equal in worth but distinct in function. When a single component elevates itself above the rest — when one cell stops cooperating and starts demanding — the system collapses.

Cancer is not a foreign invader. It is a cell that forgot its role. Empire is systemic cancer."

Thesis

The thornbush accepts the crown not because it is suited to rule — but because the suited ones refused it. And a thorn trying to be a crown is catastrophic not because thorns are evil, but because they are being something other than what they are.

Every empire is a thornbush.

Hook:

"The trees held a vote. They wanted a king. The olive tree declined. The fig tree declined. The vine declined. And so the thornbush was crowned."

The Parable: Walk through Jotham's story from Judges 9. Each tree that declined did so because it had a purpose — oil, sweetness, fruit — it could not abandon without ceasing to be itself.

The Systems Lesson: A single-cell analysis: within uniform tissue, dozens of distinct cell types, each running the same DNA but expressing it differently. No cell above another. No cell meant to rule the rest.

The Cancer Principle: Cancer is not evil. It is a cell that forgot its role. Empire is not a foreign invader. It is a node of the system that elevated itself and began consuming the whole.

The Turn: What if the decline of the olive, the fig, and the vine was not weakness — but the deepest form of wisdom? To know your function and refuse to abandon it — even when offered the crown.

The Prestige:

"A thorn doing the work of a thorn is essential. A thorn trying to be a crown is catastrophic. You were not made to rule. You were made to protect. To define edges. To defend life. That is not a lesser purpose. That is the Living Age."

Visual Notes

- Ancient forest. A circle of trees.
- Each tree visual as the parable is told — olive heavy with fruit, fig, vine
- Then the thornbush — sparse, sharp, small — with a crown placed on it
- Cut to: cancer cells consuming healthy tissue (medical visualization)
- Cut to: a brain, an ecosystem — no single node above another
- Close on: a thorn, close up, gleaming — beautiful in its function

Source Quotes

Direct quotes from Sage's own writing to draw from when scripting this episode.

"The thorns (Judges 9) must remember their true purpose. Every part in a living system has an individual purpose and no part of the living system is above another but they are all

equal but perform different functions."

"The king is not above those they serve but their equal. No hierarchy among humans — only different roles. You can have leaders without them being rulers."

"The ruler king is an agent of satan and the leader king is an agent of god. The ruler is there to be served and the leader is there to serve and lead others to do the same."

"A true leader leads at a round table."

"Growth is meaningless if it is a cancer."

"When a warrior protector stops being commanded by conscience they become a weapon of power-hungry men."

"Matthew 20:25 — 'You know the gentiles lord over one another — it may not be so among you.'"

The Living Age Trilogy